

Vision for Quality Instruction

Social Studies

The Kansas State Department of Education (KSDE) believes that all Kansas students deserve consistent access to Quality Instruction in Social Studies that makes space for them to grapple with the grey, analyzing and synthesizing multiple materials and perspectives to reason, draw conclusions, and make claims. In an effective social studies classroom, teachers follow a clear scope and sequence that allows students to inquire and investigate to develop and articulate their own unique perspectives; become academically independent citizens; and develop the skills to communicate, collaborate, and build consensus with open-mindedness and critical thinking.

To that end, Kansas' learners should have consistent access to strong social studies instruction and high-quality instructional materials aligned to the [Kansas Curricular Standards for History, Government, and Social Studies \(HGSS\)](#).

All Kansas learners deserve social studies instruction characterized by:

- **Real-World Relevance:** *Students* have opportunities to apply disciplinary knowledge, skills, and tools to identify and act on problems, issues, or needs in their communities, making connections to their lives outside of the classroom. The cultural knowledge, languages, and ways of thinking students bring with them are valued and incorporated into learning experiences wherever possible. *Teachers* strategically adapt and supplement instructional materials to address students' and local needs.
- **Inquiry Questions:** *Students* engage in sustained inquiry through compelling questions, including generating and reflecting on their own questions. *Teachers* plan units of study around compelling questions that provoke curiosity, encourage exploration, and prompt deeper understanding of social studies concepts and themes. Daily lessons explore discrete supporting questions that coherently and sequentially develop students' understanding of the unit's broader inquiry.
- **Multiple Sources & Perspectives:** *Students* read, contextualize, and analyze a selection of sources to answer inquiry questions to better understand the content studied. *Teachers* strategically select and [incorporate documents](#) that highlight multiple perspectives on a concept or topic. These documents can be from a selection of primary and secondary sources from a variety of media (text, visual, audio, or video).
- **Connections to Social Studies Literacies:** *Students* engage with Disciplinary literacy (DL) in social studies. Disciplinary literacy recognizes that the subject being studied affects how

people read, write, think, and communicate within that field. For example, a historian must know how to corroborate, source, and contextualize texts they interact with.*

- **Questions that may help focus social studies Disciplinary Literacy:**
 - How do we help students think in social studies?
 - What specialized texts do we have students read in social studies, and how do we help students access them?
- **The main foci of Disciplinary Literacy in social studies are:**
 - Inquiry cycle (questioning, research, analysis, communication),
 - Primary source analysis (often as a part of the inquiry cycle),
 - Sourcing and bias (how does knowing who wrote something change how you accept that source as "truth"?)
 - Considering point of view (how would a geographer view something different than a historian, for example)
 - Specialized vocabulary (ex: bias, stereotype, "truth" mean different things in English class than in a history class).
- **Reasoning & Argumentation:** *Students* do the work of scholars in social studies by engaging in reasoning about multiple sources and perspectives, evaluating and using selected evidence, and constructing grade-appropriate arguments in both writing and speaking. *Teachers* plan lesson tasks and assessments that give students opportunities to demonstrate the depth of their understanding by developing their own claims backed by evidence and reasoning.
- **Dialogue & Collaboration:** *Students* share ideas, build on and evaluate one another's ideas through civil discourse, and shift their thinking as new evidence emerges or compelling ideas are shared related to the lesson's inquiry. *Teachers* cultivate a community of learners in which students feel comfortable taking intellectual risks among their peers and making mistakes.

Sources:

- [Criteria for High-Quality Instructional Materials for Social Studies](#) (AIR, EdReports)
- [College, Career, and Civic Life \(C3\) Framework for Social Studies State Standards](#) (NCSS)
- * Adapted from the following:
 - <https://dpi.wi.gov/social-studies/classroom-resources/disciplinary-literacy> (Wisconsin Department of Instruction)
 - <https://www.carnegielearning.com/blog/what-is-disciplinary-literacy/> (Carnegie Learning)
 - <https://www.learner.org/series/reading-writing-in-the-disciplines/big-ideas-in-literacy-history-social-studies/> (Anneberg Foundation)